

Daily Pronunciation Exercises

One-line, repeatable drills. Pick a handful per session — 5, 10, 15, or 30 minutes' worth. Do them again tomorrow.

Perception (do this most)

- Guess the stressed syllable of 20 unfamiliar words before checking, and score yourself.
- Listen to a sentence, hum the melody back with no words, then say the real words.
- Low-pass filter a clip (Audacity, below 400Hz) and try to describe the melody you hear.
- Transcribe 30 seconds of fast native speech word-for-word and count what you missed.
- Pick 10 recorded phrases, name the most stressed word in each, and say what it implies.
- Classify 20 short utterances by tune: fall / low rise / high rise / fall-rise / rise-fall / level.

Word stress

- Say stress-shift pairs aloud, tapping the beat: PHOtograph/phoTOgrapher, eCOonomy/eco-NOmic, ANalyze/aNALysis.
- Drop your worst words into a carrier phrase: “The _____ was the issue.”
- Sprint through: necessary, secretary, temporary, category, laboratory, February — fast, with full reduction, 10x.
- Say noun/verb pairs in sentences: “We need to record the record,” “They’ll present the present.”

Rhythm & reduction

- Tap a 90bpm metronome and fit 2-3 sentences of varying length into the exact same number of beats.
- Say “DOGS EAT BONES” then “The dogs would have eaten all of the bones” in the same total time.
- Rewrite a paragraph phonetically with all reductions spelled out, then read your ugly respelling aloud.
- Say a list fast with linking, 10x: “pick it up, turn it off, an apple, a lot of it.”
- Stretch a rubber band on stressed syllables, release on weak ones, while reading any sentence.

Phrasing

- Mark thought-group boundaries on your own email/notes before reading them aloud.
- Practice both readings of an ambiguity pair until instant: “Let’s eat, Grandma” vs “Let’s eat Grandma.”
- Say questions/statements ending in a word whose stress isn’t final, keeping the stress in place: “Did you check the comPUter?”

Prominence (nucleus placement)

- Say one sentence 6 ways, moving the stress each time, and state what each version implies.
- Write 5 Q&A pairs and answer with stress only on new information, not on words repeated from the question.
- Say contrast pairs: “I said inCREASE the budget, not deCREASE it.”

Melody

- Say 15 different sentences using one target tune (start with fall-rise), then switch tunes tomorrow.
- Say “You’re going to Paris” with all 6 tunes and state what each one means.
- Say long words ending a falling sentence, keeping pitch down through the whole tail: MANAge-ment, deVELOpment, COMfortable.
- Say one neutral sentence in 5-8 different emotions and record yourself.

Discourse / calls

- Practice “mm-hm” and “uh-huh” with natural falling/rising tunes as backchannels.
- Say a filler-filled minute of speech, placing “um/uh” only at phrase boundaries, never mid-phrase.
- Record a 90-second mini-presentation with 3 signposted points, each starting on a high pitch.

Imitation (apply daily to any clip of your model speaker)

- Loop 3-8 seconds of a clip and speak simultaneously with it (chorusing), 10x through.
- Shadow a clip with a slight lag, listening and speaking at once.
- Listen, then repeat a phrase from memory with the audio off (delayed imitation).

Daily maintenance

- Record 2 minutes of unscripted speech on a random topic, review 30 seconds for one specific feature.
- After every sentence you say today, silently ask “which word was the point, and did my stress land there?”
- Compare a fresh recording of yourself to the model clip, check exactly one dimension (rhythm OR melody, never both).